after the shoot, there's a record of it," adds Kagti.

Nasir also introduced Kagti to his crew, many of whom were cast in smaller parts in *Superboys*.... "The people in Malegaon are different," says Kagti. "There is a swag that comes from being a film buff." Besides Malegaon, the movie is shot in Nashik, Deolali and Mumbai. Kagti found a key collaborator in production designer Sally White who recreated the video parlours and screening halls. "I like building sets in live locations as it gives a sense of realism," says Kagti. Much like Nasir, Kagti also dabbled in a bit of guerrilla filmmaking by placing a camera in the middle of the road in Dharavi.

Kagti and Grover take nifty cinematic liberties such as using the making-of-a-film-within-the-film device to explore the conflict that stems from a screenwriter's pride and a director's ego. There's also drama around how respect and success are vital attributes for creators. It's fitting then that the real superheroes of Malegaon find happiness in what they do, which is making films. And it's what Kagti hopes will be the impact of her film on the audience. "I really hope this film will end up inspiring anybody who aspires to do something and it's not easy for them." ■

–Suhani Singh

CINEMA

A TAUT DRAMA

Baksho Bondi was a cathartic experience for husband-wife director duo **Tanushree Das** and **Saumyananda Sahi** as well as for Tillotama Shome who stars in it

Cinema for husband-wife director duo Tanushree Das and Saumyananda Sahi is a therapeutic exercise. Their debut feature *Baksho Bondi* (*Shadowbox*), which premiered at the Berlin Film Festival recently, came as a "ladder" for both of them as well as its leading lady, Tillotama Shome.

For Das, developing the story was a means to cope with postpartum depression and the loss of her father; for Sahi, also a renowned cinematographer, it gave him the opportunity to be by his wife's side during her lows and help give shape to her dreams and stories by writing the script. As for Shome, reading emailed drafts of the script "helped her emotionally" during the pandemic as she cared for her ailing mother. "I met these two wonderful people [Das and Sahi] and I wanted to hold on to this friendship," she says. "The fiction of the film was my reality, I felt grown up enough, I felt the need to expand my film knowledge." It was the first film Shome was offered after earning widespread acclaim for her performance in the independent film, *Sir*. Much like *Sir*, *Baksho Bondi* makes optimum use of her thespian talent. It centres around Maya (Shome), mother to a troubled teen, wife to a retired army officer husband who struggles to hold onto a job, and sole breadwinner of the house.





DIRECTOR DUO Saumyananda Sahi and Tanushree Das; (bottom) Tillotama Shome in a still from the movie

Amidst the portrait of a resilient woman trying to keep her family together, Das and Sahi subtly touch on PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder) and caste and class disparity. "We didn't want to make it a clinical case but look at it from an emotional standpoint," says Sahi, who consulted therapists. "Maya is also on the verge of a breakdown. We don't pause to talk about the strain [of caring for someone]. Mental distress is a spectrum, it is not suffered by one person alone."

Adversity lurks at every corner but the filmmakers never lose sight of the love and tenderness especially evident in Maya's concern for her husband. "With art you can explore and engage and understand things which are painful, look at your own darknesses in a safe way," says Das, who also edited the film. "It is a safe space where you can engage." For Sahi, who was born and brought up in a village outside Bengaluru, the film allowed him to engage with his wife's culture. Says Sahi, "We'd collect scenes, write on postcards, shuffle them and give them shape later. Certain elements of the story like the middle were fixed."

What changed was the ending and the couple has their son, Ahaan, to thank for it. In fact, it was his birth in 2016 which made them realise the power of the story that had been brewing in their head for a while. Present throughout the shoot in Barrackpur, West Bengal, Ahaan ended up picking up his mother tongue. "He brought an innocence and asked a question and he had a point, so we went back to the drawing board," says Das. As the family soak in the success of the Berlin screenings, they look forward to sharing the film with audiences back home. ■

–Suhani Singh



SAUMYANANDA SAHI